SNHU Travel Project: Scrum-Agile Retrospective

By Titus Lamb

Being the Scrum Master for the SNHU Travel project, it was my responsibility to make sure the team understood the Agile and Scrum process. It was my job to keep the team on track and handle any issues that arose. The retrospective will be a review over everything we have done, the importance of each role, how we handled a large change midway in the Sprint, and how we can improve as a team.

The Scrum team has four important roles that each had core applications for the completion of the SNHU Travel project: Scrum Master, Product Owner, Product Tester, and Developer. As Scrum Master, I coordinated each Scrum event, kept information updated through project management tools such as Jira, and solved immediate or unforeseen problems for the team. I supported the team instead of directly commanding them to give responsibility to each member. It also helped the team communicate more effectively with one another. The Product Owner represents the client and their goals, writing them into user stories, and updating the backlog. When SNHU Travel sent in the new information regarding the new detox and wellness vacation packages, I reached out to the team to let them know immediately and updated the user stories. The Product Tester's job is to make test cases based on the Product Owner's user stories. The Product Tester actively reached out to the Product Owner to clear up any assumptions they had with the user stories, so the team didn't make any wrongly requested features. Lastly, the Developers job is to carry out each backlog request, ask questions for clarification, and react appropriately to any changes. The Developer actively emailed the Product Owner and Tester to clear up any questions when the backlog was updated, and the user stories were changed.

Using the Scrum-Agile approach, user stories were completed by breaking requirements into small user requests that told us what they wanted, why they wanted it, and the acceptance criteria for the feature. During sprint planning, the team would organize each story from the highest priority to lowest. A method the team used to organize the stories was affinity grouping, which entailed the team grouping each backlog item into groups of small, medium, and large. This method was very time efficient and encouraged communication through the team. Daily Scrums encouraged the team to explicitly clarify what the requirements were for a task to be completed. This ensured that a task was not stuck in development due to vague and unclear goals.

Midway through the project, SNHU Travel changed their goals, which emphasized wellness and detox packages. This was not what we had originally been working on. Since we were following an agile-based approach, we responded immediately to correct the project. The Product Owner updated the backlog, backlog priorities, and user stories. The developer and Product Tester kept in communication to clear up any assumptions or misunderstandings, with the Product Tester updating the test cases. As Scrum Master, I made sure the team stayed organized and reacted accordingly.

The team was able to stay up to date throughout the project with the help of my clear, direct communication as Scrum Master. I made sure to respond to any questions the team had and communicated directly on when the team should meet. Because I was not commanding each member but rather supporting them, the team was able to communicate effectively on their own. For example, the Product Owner messaged the Developer with the new backlog requirements. The Developer not only responded but made sure to ask questions to clear up any assumptions they could have made:

Good afternoon, Christy,

I am beginning development on the new plan for SNHU Travel and have some questions about it.

1. What is the new priority for the backlog in this sprint?
2. Does any feature need to be scrapped with the new changes?

Please let me know immediately if you need any clarification. If you could reply by 10/8 at 6:00 PM, that would be great.

Thank you,

Titus Lamb.

This worked as effective communication because stating a direct time to respond and listing the questions gives a clear understanding of what the developer wants and when.

Many organizational tools and Scrum-Agile principles were used for the completion of the project. One of the organizational tools that helped the team be successful was Jira, a software application that the team can use to share the backlog, backlog priorities, scrum board, and other communication features to keep the team updated with one another. This all-in-one software was effective at bringing all information into one compact workstation that each member had full access to. This kept information synced throughout the entire team and made updates or changes immediately. Of course, it had the tradeoff of only being effective if the Product Owner and team consistently update it themselves. One principle that kept tasks moving forward in development was defining what it means to be done. This gave the team clear goals on each task to make sure they were not stuck in development. Scrum events laid out the groundwork for the success of the project. Sprint Planning created the goal for the team and the work to reach it, the Daily Scrum kept the team updated and tasks completed, and the Sprint Review retrieved feedback from the client. All these principles and tools contributed to the project so the team could work at their best and respond accordingly.

The use of the Scrum-Agile approach has its own positives and negatives. The approach gave the team flexibility through backlog refinement and priority changes, transparency using tools such as Jira to keep all information open for each member, constant feedback from Daily Scrums and Sprint Reviews, and improvement using retrospectives such as this which can solve previous problems for the next project. A couple negatives however are that we cannot predict the direction of the project as changes are common, and while team member independence can be a good thing, lack of work ethic from one member can bring the whole team down. While these negatives are important to consider, I believe Scrum-Agile was the best approach to the SNHU Project. Due to the client changing their direction, we had to change priorities and update the backlog to appropriately respond to it. While these changes could have cost some time, using the waterfall approach could have ended the project entirely. Having a project where direction can change easily, and edits or changes must be made should absolutely use the Scrum-Agile approach such as this one.